

God-Man or God's Man: Trinitarian and Biblical Unitarian Christologies in Light of Second Temple Wisdom and Agency

Framing the Question and the Historical-Literary Method

Traditional, church-dogmatic Trinitarianism—especially as formalized in the fourth and fifth centuries—confesses one God in three equally divine “Persons” and, by extension, confesses Jesus as ontologically God the Son who assumed a full human nature (the “God-man” claim). [1] The question posed here is whether that *ontological* claim is the most sensible inference from (a) Israel’s Scriptures, (b) Second Temple Jewish thought and idiom, and (c) the New Testament’s own literary patterns—especially when the New Testament repeatedly depicts Jesus as God’s commissioned representative, the “one sent,” and when it draws heavily on Wisdom/Word traditions to speak about God’s action in the world. [2]

A historically grounded approach begins by resisting later categories as controlling lenses—especially later metaphysical vocabulary (e.g., “one substance,” “hypostasis,” “two natures”) that is absent from the New Testament and only becomes doctrinally decisive in the post-apostolic controversies. [3] Instead, it asks what conceptual tools were already available inside Second Temple Judaism for (i) speaking about God’s presence and action without multiplying gods, and (ii) speaking about God’s commissioned representatives who bear God’s authority, speak in God’s name, and can even be addressed with “divine” language in a representational sense. [4]

This study argues that the Biblical Unitarian reading—Jesus as God’s truly human Messiah and uniquely empowered agent (“God’s man”), not God in an ontological sense—offers a more context-sensitive, less anachronistic, and more internally coherent explanation of the New Testament’s “high” language about Jesus. It does so by integrating two Second Temple frameworks: (a) Wisdom/Word (logos) discourse as a way to speak about God’s own self-expression and creative/redemptive activity, and (b) agency (shaliah) as a way to speak about a sent representative who may bear the sender’s authority, name, and prerogatives without being the sender by nature. [5]

Second Temple Categories for “God Present and Acting”: Wisdom, Word, and Intermediary Discourse

Second Temple Judaism inherited a deep commitment to the uniqueness of Israel’s God while also developing rich ways of describing God’s immanence—God “reaching into” creation—through personified or hypostatized divine attributes such as Wisdom, Word, Presence (Shekinah), and other “intermediary” idioms. Classic scholarship on Aramaic and later Jewish traditions (e.g., Memra/“Word” language) shows that intermediary language often arises as a reverent solution to biblical anthropomorphisms: Scripture depicts God “speaking,” “walking,” “dwelling,” and “appearing,” while later interpreters seek language that preserves divine transcendence without denying divine action in history. [6]

Within Jewish Wisdom literature itself, Wisdom is frequently personified in strikingly personal terms while still functioning as a poetic-theological vehicle for God’s own wise ordering of creation and covenant life. In Sirach[7] 24, Wisdom “comes forth” from the Most High, traverses creation, and then is portrayed as taking up a dwelling among God’s people in a way that the book explicitly connects with Torah (law), collapsing “Wisdom” into God’s covenantal instruction rather than introducing a second deity. [8] In Wisdom of Solomon[9] 7, Wisdom is described as a “breath” and “emanation” of God’s glory, “a reflection of eternal light,” and “an image of [God’s] goodness,” language that later New Testament authors echo when describing God’s redemptive action in and through Christ. [10]

This Wisdom discourse also appears in other Second Temple streams. In 1 Enoch[11] 42, Wisdom is portrayed as seeking a dwelling among humans yet finding none, returning to the heavens—again a dramatic personification that functions to interpret the moral and covenantal state of humanity rather than to teach an ontological plurality within God. [12] These motifs supply a ready-made Jewish grammar for later claims like “Wisdom/Word came to dwell among us”: such language can be read as the embodiment of God’s own wise purpose in a human life, rather than as the incarnation of a pre-existent divine person in a later Nicene sense. [13]

The Hellenistic Jewish philosopher Philo of Alexandria[14] illustrates both the potential and the limits of this discourse: he can speak of the Logos in ways that approach “second God” language while still treating the Logos as the means of God’s ordering and knowability rather than as an independent rival deity, and modern analysis stresses the complexity and variability of his Logos concept. [15] The crucial point for Christology is not that all Jews believed in a “second divine person,” but that many Jewish texts already used elevated, quasi-personal language for God’s own self-expression (Wisdom/Word) in ways compatible with rigorous monotheistic devotion. [16]

Agency and Representation: Shaliaḥ, “Sent” Christology, and the Biblical Logic of Delegated Authority

Alongside Wisdom/Word discourse, Jewish tradition also developed a strong conceptual framework for authorized representation: the shaliaḥ (legal emissary/agent). In later rabbinic formulation, the principle is succinct: “a person’s messenger is like the person himself,” stated explicitly in Mishnah Berakhot[17] 5:5. [18] Two cautions are necessary: first, the Mishnah is post-70 and later than the New Testament; second, not every rabbinic legal detail can be assumed for the first century. Yet the *logic* it codifies—authorized emissaries acting in the sender’s name—fits long-standing ancient Mediterranean practices of envoy representation and is widely used by Johannine scholars precisely because the Fourth Gospel is saturated with “sending” language and with claims that the Son does not act from himself but speaks and works what the Father authorizes. [19]

Modern treatments of Johannine theology explicitly argue that agency (sometimes described with the diplomatic term “plenipotentiary”) is a leitmotif integrating mission and Christology in John: Jesus is portrayed as God’s empowered representative, and after the resurrection the disciples are commissioned to continue that mission representationally. [20] This is not a marginal observation; it is driven by the Gospel’s own rhetoric—Jesus as the one “sent,” whose authority is derived, whose judgment is entrusted, and whose words are not self-originating. [21]

Critically for the “God-Man vs. God’s man” question, agency provides a culturally intelligible explanation for why an authorized representative can bear divine titles or prerogatives *functionally* without possessing the sender’s identity *ontologically*. That distinction is visible already in Israel’s Scriptures. In Exodus, God tells Moses, “I have made you as God to Pharaoh” (NASB1995), language that clearly elevates Moses’ representational authority without turning Moses into YHWH by nature. [22] In Psalm 82 (and Jesus’ citation of it), the category “gods” can be applied in a judicial/representational register to beings who receive God’s word and exercise derivative authority; interpreters differ on whether Psalm 82 imagines human judges, heavenly beings, or a “divine council,” but the Psalm’s own logic still distinguishes YHWH as the supreme judge from the subordinate “gods” who are judged, which makes the passage usable as an argument that the label “god(s)” can function in a non-ontological way. [23]

The New Testament itself explicitly foregrounds this “sent agent” relationship. Jesus defines eternal life as knowing the Father “the only true God” and himself as the one the Father “sent” (John 17:3, NASB1995), a formulation that reads naturally as a sender-agent pairing, not as a revelation that the “only true God” is a tri-personal being in which Jesus is ontologically included. [24] Paul likewise distinguishes “one God, the Father” from “one Lord” Jesus Christ (1 Cor 8:6, NASB1995) and speaks of “one God” and “one mediator... the man Christ Jesus” (1 Tim 2:5, NASB), which coheres directly with agency: God is the ultimate source; the Messiah is the appointed mediator through whom God’s purposes are enacted. [25] Peter’s Pentecost preaching similarly presents Jesus as “a man attested to you by God” through whom God performed mighty works (Acts 2:22, NASB1995), which is precisely the grammar of divine action through an authorized human instrument. [26]

A Trinitarian counterargument deserves to be stated fairly: many Trinitarians insist that agency language in John does not exclude ontological deity; it simply describes the Son's mission within the Trinity (especially in incarnational "economic" roles). [27] The Unitarian reply is that this move risks smuggling later metaphysics into the first-century texts: the New Testament's thick sender-agent rhetoric, coupled with its repeated "God raised him," "God exalted him," and "God gave him authority" patterns, fits agency naturally, whereas ontological equality plus functional subordination requires additional metaphysical distinctions that are not explicit in the apostolic proclamation itself. [28]

High Christology Revisited Through Wisdom and Agency

The central Unitarian claim in this study is not that the New Testament's christological language is "low," but that its "high" language is often *Wisdom/Word* language and *agency* language—forms of speech already at home in Second Temple Judaism—rather than direct metaphysical assertions that Jesus is ontologically identical with God. This can be tested case by case in the passages most commonly deployed as Trinitarian proof-texts.

John 1:1–18 is often treated as decisive for ontological deity ("the Word was God"), but several observations complicate that inference without requiring theological special pleading. First, the Prologue itself is saturated with the very *Wisdom/Word* idiom already seen in Jewish intermediary traditions, in which God's Word is God's self-expression "from" God and "with" God, and later Jewish reflection explicitly sought ways to speak of God's action while avoiding crude anthropomorphism. [29] Second, the grammatical debate about the anarthrous predicate θεός in John 1:1c is genuine: classic linguistic discussions emphasize that such constructions can carry a qualitative sense ("the Word was divine," i.e., expressing God's nature) rather than identifying the Word with "the God" of the preceding clause, and scholarly treatments warn against simplistic appeals to "Colwell's rule" as a mechanical proof. [30] A *Wisdom-agency* synthesis can therefore read John 1 as proclaiming that God's own creative and revelatory self-expression (*Word/Wisdom*) has been embodied in the historical life of Jesus ("the Word became flesh"), without requiring that an eternal divine person literally became a human being in later conciliar categories. [31]

Hebrews 1:1–4 provides an even clearer bridge between *Wisdom* language and christological proclamation. The description of the Son as "the radiance of [God's] glory and the exact representation of His nature" (Heb 1:3, NASB1995) closely parallels *Wisdom* of Solomon's language about *Wisdom* as "a reflection of eternal light... and an image of [God's] goodness." [32] A focused study of Hebrews' exordium argues that the author borrows established *Wisdom* tradition language (especially from *Wisdom* of Solomon 7:25–27) to describe the Son as the concrete manifestation of God's presence and action, deploying Hellenistic-Jewish sapiential idiom for a historical reality rather than presenting a philosophical account of a pre-temporal divine hypostasis in Nicene terms. [33] That reading coheres with the epistle's broader emphasis on Jesus as mediator and high priest—roles that presuppose distinction between God and the one who mediates God to humanity. [34]

Philippians 2:6–11 is commonly read as a pre-existence/incarnation narrative, but serious scholarship recognizes competing readings, including a “Second Adam” or vocation-of-Image-of-God reading in which the hymn narrates the earthly Jesus’ obedience and subsequent exaltation rather than the voluntary “incarnation” of an already equal divine person. [35] Importantly, even treatments sympathetic to ontological deity concede that key terms (μορφή, ἁρπαγμός) and the hymn’s narrative logic are contested and that multiple interpretations have gained scholarly approval. [36] For the Unitarian-agency reading, the hymn’s climactic causal structure—“therefore God highly exalted him”—is not incidental: exaltation is portrayed as God’s act in response to the Messiah’s obedience, which fits agency and messianic enthronement patterns straightforwardly (God grants authority; the agent exercises it to God’s glory), while the later Trinitarian “humiliation of the eternal Son” reading adds ontological premises not supplied by the hymn itself. [37]

Colossians 1:15–20 (the “Christ hymn”) is also frequently cited for cosmic pre-existence and ontological deity, yet scholarship widely recognizes its deep indebtedness to Jewish Wisdom traditions and imagery (including “image,” creation-ordering, and cosmic reconciliation language). [38] A Wisdom-Christology approach can affirm the poem’s maximal claims about Christ’s role without collapsing him into God ontologically: God’s own wise purpose in creation and new creation is embodied and enacted “in/through” the Messiah, who is portrayed as the visible “image” of the invisible God and the firstborn in rank. [39] This is precisely where agency matters: “through whom” language is compatible with Israel’s insistence that God is the ultimate creator while allowing for God’s instrumental action through divine Wisdom/Word and through God’s appointed agent. [40]

Passages where Jesus is called or addressed as “God” require special care, since the Unitarian thesis here is not that such texts do not exist, but that they are best explained as representational/functional uses of divine language, often within liturgical or rhetorical peaks. John 20:28 (“My Lord and my God,” NASB1995) is rightly recognized as a climactic confession, yet even within John the dominant frame repeatedly emphasizes source and derivation—Jesus sent by the Father, doing the Father’s works, speaking the Father’s words—and John’s own Jesus distinguishes himself from “the only true God” (John 17:3). [41] Hebrews 1:8 (quoting Psalm 45) likewise can be read as royal-messianic enthronement language in which exalted address functions representationally within the king’s God-given authority, especially given the broader biblical pattern of derivative “god” language for commissioned figures (Exod 7:1; Ps 82) and the epistle’s own emphasis on the Son’s appointment and inheritance. [42]

A crucial set of “high” texts hinges on Greek syntax rather than narrative logic—especially Titus 2:13 and 2 Peter 1:1, often appealed to via Granville Sharp’s rule. Yet careful grammatical and contextual scholarship shows that these are not slam-dunks: major discussions argue that the application of Sharp’s rule in these passages is debated and that contextual parallels (notably the close relationship between Titus 2:11–14 and 1 Tim 2:1–7) pressure interpreters not to read θεός as a title applied to Jesus in Titus 2:13, since in the parallel passage θεός clearly does not refer to “the man Christ Jesus.” [43] Further, technical debate within Greek scholarship has criticized overly confident deployments of Sharp’s rule in precisely these “remaining” texts (Titus 2:13; 2 Pet 1:1), pressing potential difficulties in assumptions about proper names and the limits of the rule’s application. [44] The Unitarian-agency thesis thus does not depend on “explaining away” an unambiguous mass of “Jesus = God” proofs; it argues that the most debated texts remain debated for sound linguistic reasons, and that the clearer, repeated sender-agent and “one God, the Father” statements should set the baseline for interpretation. [45]

A fair Trinitarian counterargument is that early Christ-devotion practices (prayer, worship language, applying YHWH-texts to Jesus) imply more than agency; they imply inclusion in divine identity. Yet Second Temple Judaism itself already provides categories for reverencing God’s self-manifestation and honoring God’s authorized representative without abandoning monotheism—precisely because honoring the agent can be construed as honoring the sender whose authority the agent bears. [46] The Unitarian claim is that agency plus Wisdom/Word idiom can account for both the exalted language *and* the persistent asymmetry (God sends/raises/exalts; Jesus obeys/receives/is appointed), whereas ontological equality requires later philosophical distinctions (immanent vs. economic Trinity, two-natures doctrine) that are historically downstream from the apostolic texts. [47]

From Apostolic Proclamation to Conciliar Orthodoxy: Why Later Trinitarian Metaphysics is Not a Neutral Reading Lens

Historically, the doctrinal form of Trinitarianism is not simply “what the New Testament says” repeated in different words; it is a specific theological synthesis hammered out in controversy, using technical terms (*homoousios*, *hypostasis*, “two natures”) that were chosen precisely because earlier language was judged insufficiently precise to settle disputes. [48] Standard historical accounts emphasize that key fourth-century terminology was contested, that the Nicene settlement was not universally welcomed at the time, and that later theological development drew heavily on philosophical vocabularies available in the Greco-Roman intellectual environment. [49] This matters methodologically: if a doctrine is stabilized by later metaphysical decisions and technical language, then reading those same metaphysical decisions back into first-century Jewish texts is not automatically “the unbiased” reading; it is a theological commitment that must be argued for rather than assumed. [50]

At the same time, it is historically important not to romanticize Second Temple Judaism as conceptually uniform. Jewish texts and later rabbinic polemics attest debates about divine intermediary concepts and “two powers” type speculation; scholarship on these debates shows both that such speculation existed and that it was contested within Jewish monotheism. [51] In other words, the mere existence of intermediary discourse does not automatically validate Nicene ontology, but it does demonstrate that the New Testament’s elevated christological language could emerge from Jewish categories (Wisdom/Word, agency, exaltation) without requiring that Jesus be ontologically identical with God. [52]

A crucial conceptual bridge here is the Jewish notion that “pre-existence” can sometimes mean pre-ordination in God’s plan rather than literal personal existence before birth. One prominent scholarly articulation of this Jewish pattern highlights that various things (Torah, repentance, even the Messiah’s “name”) are spoken of as “pre-existent” in the sense of being established in God’s intention from the beginning. [53] This is precisely the kind of conceptual resource that allows Wisdom Christology to be read as “God’s eternal wisdom/purpose now embodied in a person in time,” rather than “an eternal person took on flesh,” and it gives historical plausibility to Unitarian readings of Johannine and Pauline “from heaven” language as mission-idiom and proleptic plan-idiom within a Jewish worldview. [54]

Which Reading is More Sensible, and What It Implies for the Biblical Jesus and the Gospel

If we begin as “logically careful but theologically untrained” readers, the question becomes one of explanatory power with minimal anachronism. The New Testament repeatedly and explicitly differentiates God (as ultimate source) from Jesus (as the Messiah sent by God), framing salvation history as God acting through the human Messiah: the Father is “the only true God,” and Jesus is “the one sent”; there is “one God” and “one mediator... the man Christ Jesus”; Jesus is “a man attested by God” through whom God worked. [55] Those lines are not rare footnotes; they function as programmatic theological summaries. When such summaries are placed alongside Second Temple Wisdom/Word discourse (where God’s wisdom is personified yet remains God’s own self-expression) and alongside agency logic (where the authorized agent can bear the sender’s authority and even be addressed in the sender’s stead), the Biblical Unitarian model gains substantial plausibility as a historically native reading strategy. [56]

Traditional Trinitarianism can, of course, *reinterpret* these summaries by appealing to later categories (economic vs. immanent Trinity; incarnational subordination; “two natures”), and it can plausibly claim that high-devotion patterns require ontological deity. [57] Yet the cost of that move is methodological: it installs later metaphysics as the rule by which first-century Jewish discourse must be decoded, even where the texts themselves already supply conceptual tools (Wisdom/Word; agency; exaltation) that render the language intelligible within Jewish monotheism. [58] The Unitarian-agency reading is therefore “more sensible” in the narrow historical-literary sense that it (a) honors the New Testament’s persistent asymmetry and sender-agent structure, (b) explains “high” language as rooted in Jewish Wisdom/Word idiom that can be embodied and enacted in history, and (c) interprets debated grammatical constructions with due caution rather than building ontology on disputed syntax. [59]

Reintroducing the biblical Jesus within this corrected framework does not diminish him; it clarifies him. The New Testament’s own center of gravity is that God fulfilled His promises by anointed human obedience: Jesus is the Messiah who perfectly embodies God’s wisdom, reveals God’s character, performs God’s works as God’s authorized agent, and then—precisely because he is faithful—becomes the uniquely exalted Lord through resurrection and enthronement. [60] The gospel’s “original” logic is not that God came to die because God cannot forgive otherwise, but that God acted in history through His servant-Messiah, validating him by resurrection, and calling the world to repentance, faith, and allegiance to the Lord He appointed—so that “to the glory of God the Father” the nations confess Jesus as Lord. [61]

The implications are substantial. If Jesus is understood primarily as God’s shaliah-like representative and Wisdom embodied rather than as ontological deity, then the New Testament’s insistence on the Father as the one God regains its simplest force, and the unity of monotheism is preserved without metaphysical complexity unfamiliar to Second Temple Jewish categories. [62] Salvation is then grasped as covenantal and eschatological: the one God saves by raising and enthroning the human Messiah, appointing him mediator and judge, and extending mercy to all who come to know the Father through the one He sent. [63] In that sense, “God’s man” Christology presses the church back toward the earliest proclamation’s emphasis: the Messiah’s true mission is to enact God’s wise redemptive purpose in history, to reconcile humanity to the Father by faithful obedience unto death, and to inaugurate the new creation under God’s reign—so that worship terminates in God as source, while honoring Jesus as the uniquely authorized Lord through whom God’s kingdom arrives. [64]

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